

Clematis

SHOWY TEPALS

The sepals and petals of some flowers, like the clematis, are so similar that it is difficult to tell them apart. These parts are known as tepals (p. 16) and may be brightly colored.

Ray floret with a single ray

Brightly colored tepal

Disk floret with outer ray florets removed

White ray florets

Disk florets

Umbels resemble thistle heads

Eryngo has unusual dome-shaped umbels (flower clusters)

Hogweed has typical umbrella-shaped umbels (flower clusters)

Chamomile, part of the daisy family

COMPOSITE FLOWERS

The flower heads of plants such as sunflowers and daisies are known as composite flowers, because they are composed of many tiny flowers called florets clustered together. Sunflower heads have many hundreds of florets—disk florets in the center of the flower head, and ray florets, which consist of a single petal-like ray around the outer edge. In the yarrow (see below), each flower head is made up of many individual disk florets surrounded by about five ray florets. These flower heads are crowded together to form a bigger cluster of about 1,000 florets.

Sunflower

Eryngo

FLOWERS IN UMBELS

Not only are small flowers more visible when they are clustered together, but flower clusters also provide a better landing platform for pollinating insects. Plants in the family known as the umbellifers, such as hogweed (see right), have their flowers grouped together in umbrella-shaped clusters called umbels. Eryngo (see left) is an unusual umbellifer, since it has dome-shaped umbels.

Floret cluster

Cultivated yarrow

Hogweed